

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Corporate Strategy English



Conversation lab

12 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For corporate strategy, CEO office, transformation, corporate development, strategic finance, product strategy, and internal consulting teams.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

- 01 CEO Request: 'We Need a Strategy'
- 02 Where-to-Play Debate: Enterprise vs Mid-Market
- 03 Five Forces: Growth Does Not Mean Profit
- 04 Portfolio Review: Protect the Core or Fund the New Bet
- 05 Resource Allocation: Everyone Wants Flat Growth
- 06 Market Entry: Build, Buy, or Partner
- 07 M&A Synergy Challenge
- 08 Scenario Planning: Regulatory Uncertainty
- 09 Strategy vs Operational Effectiveness
- 10 KPI Conflict: Activity Metrics vs Strategic Outcomes
- 11 Board Deck: Too Much Analysis, No Decision
- 12 Sunk Cost: Politically Protected Initiative

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

CEO Request: 'We Need a Strategy'

The CEO asks the strategy team for a strategy, but the request sounds like a list of initiatives.

Roles: CEO / Strategy lead / Strategy manager

CEO: We need a strategy for next year. Give me the top twenty initiatives.

Strategy lead: We can build the initiative list, but first we need the strategic choice behind it.

Strategy manager: If the output is only a project list, we may miss the real decision. Are we trying to defend the core, enter a new segment, improve margins, or shift resources toward higher-growth businesses?

CEO: All of the above.

Strategy manager: Then the first decision is prioritization. We should define the few choices that matter most, the tradeoffs they imply, and the resources that must move.

CEO: Start by comparing the core choices and the resource constraints.

Strategy manager: I will prepare a short decision paper before translating the chosen direction into initiatives.

Notice the professional language

Strategic choice - Decision about where to focus, how to win, what to build, and what not to do.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Where-to-Play Debate: Enterprise vs Mid-Market

A leadership team is debating whether to prioritize enterprise customers or mid-market customers.

Roles: CRO / Product head / Strategy manager

CRO: Enterprise logos create credibility. We should focus there.

Product head: Mid-market customers adopt faster and need fewer custom features.

Strategy manager: The where-to-play choice affects product roadmap, sales motion, implementation cost, pricing, and support model. Enterprise may increase contract value, but mid-market may improve velocity and margins.

CRO: Can we do both?

Strategy manager: Possibly, but not with the same operating model. If we choose both, we need explicit segmentation and different service levels, not one vague strategy.

CRO: Show the economics and service requirements for each segment separately.

Strategy manager: I will identify the capabilities that can be shared and where distinct operating arrangements would be needed.

Notice the professional language

Operating model - How structure, roles, processes, governance, incentives, and capabilities support strategy.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Five Forces: Growth Does Not Mean Profit

A team wants to enter a fast-growing market but has not examined industry structure.

Roles: Business unit GM / Analyst / Strategy manager / GM

Business unit GM: The market is growing 18 percent. We should enter quickly.

Analyst: Growth is strong, but supplier power and buyer power are also high.

Strategy manager: Market growth is attractive, but the profit pool may be weak. If buyers can switch easily, suppliers control key inputs, and substitutes are improving, growth may not translate into returns.

GM: So you are saying no?

Strategy manager: Not necessarily. I am saying entry needs a clear position, a barrier we can build, and economics that survive competitive pressure.

Business unit GM: I will bring evidence on switching costs and supplier concentration.

Strategy manager: That will help test the entry thesis instead of treating market growth as proof of attractive returns.

Notice the professional language

Profit pool - Where profit accumulates across segments, value chain positions, or business models.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Portfolio Review: Protect the Core or Fund the New Bet

A mature business funds the company, but a new opportunity needs investment.

Roles: Core BU leader / Innovation lead / Strategy manager

Core BU leader: Our unit generates the cash. Cutting our budget will damage the business.

Innovation lead: Without investment, the new platform will miss the window.

Strategy manager: The portfolio question is not which team deserves funding. It is what role each business plays. The core must remain healthy, but some resources may need to shift if the new platform is the stronger future value pool.

Core BU leader: That sounds like punishing performance.

Strategy manager: I would frame it as funding enterprise value. We should define the minimum investment to protect the core and the incremental investment needed to test the new platform's thesis.

Core BU leader: Let's agree on what investment protects the core before debating the remainder.

Strategy manager: I will compare that floor with the staged funding needed to test the new platform, including the consequences of deferral.

Notice the professional language

Portfolio language should reduce personal defensiveness.

Resource allocation must connect to enterprise value, not politics.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Resource Allocation: Everyone Wants Flat Growth

Every business unit requests a similar budget increase despite different performance and market opportunities.

Roles: CFO / BU leader / Strategy manager

CFO: Every BU is asking for 8 percent more. That is not a strategy.

BU leader: We all have growth plans.

Strategy manager: Equal increases may feel fair, but they ignore opportunity cost. We should allocate based on market attractiveness, advantage, capital intensity, confidence in execution, and strategic role.

BU leader: My team will see that as a cut.

Strategy manager: Then we need transparent decision rules. Some units may get growth capital, some may get productivity targets, and some may need option funding rather than full-scale investment.

CFO: I will ask each unit to use the same assumptions and explain its strategic role.

Strategy manager: Then we can compare opportunity cost and execution capacity without assuming an equal increase is the best allocation.

Notice the professional language

Opportunity cost - Value sacrificed by keeping scarce resources in a lower-priority use.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Market Entry: Build, Buy, or Partner

The company wants to enter an adjacent market but lacks several capabilities.

Roles: Corporate development / Operations / Strategy manager / CEO

Corporate development: We can acquire a player and accelerate entry.

Operations: Integration could distract the organization for two years.

Strategy manager: The route depends on speed, control, capability gap, integration risk, and economics. Build gives control but may be slow. Buy gives access but may overpay. Partner creates optionality but limits control.

CEO: What do you recommend?

Strategy manager: Start with a partnership to validate demand and operating requirements, while screening acquisition targets if the thesis proves attractive.

Corporate development: Bring the pilot objectives, exit conditions, and capability gaps for the partnership option.

Strategy manager: I will compare those with the acquisition and build alternatives before presenting the recommended route as a decision.

Notice the professional language

Build-buy-partner language should compare route, not just preference.

Options can be a strategy under uncertainty.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

M&A Synergy Challenge

A deal team presents synergy estimates that sound optimistic.

Roles: Deal lead / CFO / Strategy manager

Deal lead: The acquisition creates 60 million in annual synergies.

CFO: Where exactly do those synergies come from?

Strategy manager: We should separate revenue synergies, cost synergies, tax or procurement benefits, and capability synergies. Each needs an owner, timing, one-time cost, and confidence level.

Deal lead: The revenue synergies are strategic.

Strategy manager: Strategic is not enough. Which customers, which products, which channel, what attach rate, and what evidence tells us the combined company can capture it?

Deal lead: I will ask each synergy owner for the evidence and implementation cost.

Strategy manager: Separate uncertain revenue opportunities from more directly assessable cost actions, and avoid counting the same benefit twice.

Notice the professional language

Synergy language should move from headline value to source, timing, owner, and evidence.

Revenue synergies usually need especially careful challenge.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Scenario Planning: Regulatory Uncertainty

A new regulation could change the economics of a business model.

Roles: General counsel / Strategy director / Strategy manager / CEO

General counsel: We do not know how the rule will be finalized.

Strategy director: Then we need scenarios.

Strategy manager: Let's build only scenarios that would change our decision. For each one, we need trigger indicators, financial impact, operational implications, and moves that are no-regrets across scenarios.

CEO: What can we do now?

Strategy manager: We can reduce exposure in the highest-risk product, invest in compliance capability, and create an option to shift the model if the strict scenario becomes more likely.

General counsel: Identify what evidence would make us switch from one plan to another.

Strategy manager: I will define observable triggers and review points, with the regulatory questions routed to the appropriate advisers.

Notice the professional language

Scenario planning should guide decisions, not decorate decks.

Use trigger indicators to avoid passive waiting.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 09 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Strategy vs Operational Effectiveness

A cost-reduction program is being presented as the company's strategy.

Roles: COO / Strategy lead / Strategy manager

COO: Our strategy is to improve productivity by 12 percent.

Strategy lead: That is important, but it may be operational effectiveness rather than strategy.

Strategy manager: Productivity improvement can support strategy, but it does not answer where we will compete differently or how we will win. We need to connect the cost program to a position: lower-cost leadership, reinvestment in growth, or a more focused operating model.

COO: So the cost program is not strategic?

Strategy manager: It can be strategic if it enables a choice. By itself, it is an initiative with financial benefit.

COO: I will explain what the productivity gain would enable us to do differently.

Strategy manager: That links the operational program to a strategic choice and makes its role in the wider plan clearer.

Notice the professional language

Strategic choice - Decision about where to focus, how to win, what to build, and what not to do.

Operating model - How structure, roles, processes, governance, incentives, and capabilities support strategy.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 10 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

KPI Conflict: Activity Metrics vs Strategic Outcomes

A transformation dashboard shows many green projects, but business results are flat.

Roles: Transformation office / CEO / Strategy manager

Transformation office: Ninety percent of initiatives are on track.

CEO: Then why is margin not improving?

Strategy manager: The dashboard may be tracking activity rather than value. We need to link initiatives to value drivers: price, volume, mix, cost-to-serve, retention, working capital, and capital intensity.

Transformation office: The teams like milestone tracking.

Strategy manager: Milestones are useful, but the executive dashboard should show whether strategic outcomes are moving, not just whether workstreams are busy.

Transformation office: Keep the milestones, but add the value-driver measures and their owners.

Strategy manager: I will check the definitions and timing so the dashboard can distinguish completed activity from realized outcomes.

Notice the professional language

Green status can hide weak value delivery.

Strategic KPIs should connect to value drivers.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 11 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Board Deck: Too Much Analysis, No Decision

The strategy team has a 70-page deck but no clear board decision.

Roles: Board chair / Strategy VP / Strategy manager

Board chair: What decision do you need from us?

Strategy VP: We wanted to share the full market analysis.

Strategy manager: The analysis supports one decision: whether to shift 200 million from legacy expansion to the digital platform over three years. The board needs the strategic logic, downside case, risk controls, and milestones for releasing capital.

Board chair: Then lead with that.

Strategy manager: Agreed. We can move the market detail to appendix and open with the choice, recommendation, and resource implications.

Board chair: Include the conditions for releasing each tranche of capital.

Strategy manager: I will show the proposed milestones, downside assumptions, and decisions requiring board authority in the opening pages.

Notice the professional language

Board communication should be decision-led.

Appendix detail should support the recommendation, not bury it.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 12 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Sunk Cost: Politically Protected Initiative

A senior sponsor wants to continue a failing initiative because the company has already invested heavily.

Roles: Sponsor / CFO / Strategy manager

Sponsor: We have spent two years on this. We cannot stop now.

CFO: The economics have deteriorated.

Strategy manager: The prior investment is real, but the decision should be based on future value, remaining cost, strategic fit, and alternatives. Continuing only because we already spent money would increase opportunity cost.

Sponsor: Stopping will look like failure.

Strategy manager: We can position the recommendation as disciplined reallocation. The learning still has value, but the next dollar may create more value elsewhere.

Sponsor: I will review the remaining commitments and the cost of stopping.

Strategy manager: Compare those with the future value of continuing and the alternatives, while treating prior spending as history rather than a reason by itself.

Notice the professional language

Opportunity cost - Value sacrificed by keeping scarce resources in a lower-priority use.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

SHARED CASE

An executive asks for a "growth strategy" but has not specified whether the priority is revenue, profit, or market entry.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Which outcome are we trying to improve, over what period? Revenue growth, profit improvement, and entry into a new market may require different choices. Let's define the decision first.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Strategic Choices: Ambition, Where to Play, How to Win, and Tradeoffs

SHARED CASE

A team can invest in its core service or enter a new segment. The same staff would support both, and capacity is limited.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Cover this until after your first attempt

The two options compete for the same team. Expanding the core uses existing capabilities; entering the segment requires new ones. We should make the resource tradeoff explicit before selecting a direction.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Industry Structure, Competitive Dynamics, and Profit Pools

SHARED CASE

A market estimate is based on total industry spending, but the company can serve only one customer segment.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

Total industry spending is broader than our addressable opportunity. I'll separate the overall market from the segment we can serve and explain the assumptions used to estimate our potential share.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Business Models, Unit Economics, Capabilities, and Advantage

SHARED CASE

A new service has positive revenue growth but negative contribution after variable delivery costs. A slide calls growth proof of a sound business model.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Growth shows demand, but it does not by itself demonstrate attractive unit economics. Let's explain the revenue and variable costs per unit before drawing conclusions about the model.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Portfolio Strategy, Capital Allocation, and Resource Reallocation

SHARED CASE

Two divisions request the same investment budget. Neither proposal explains what work would stop if it were funded.

Role A | Responding professional

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Useful expressions

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could each division identify the expected benefit, key assumption, and activity it would deprioritize? That would let us compare the proposals as allocation choices rather than separate wish lists.

Second round

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Growth Strategy, Market Entry, Partnerships, and M&A Logic

SHARED CASE

An acquisition proposal lists possible cost savings. No integration plan or implementation estimate has been prepared.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

These are potential synergies, not confirmed savings. I'll distinguish the opportunity from the work and cost required to achieve it so the proposal presents a balanced strategic case.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Uncertainty, Scenarios, Strategic Options, and Risk Posture

SHARED CASE

A planning workshop has a base case and a downside case. The team wants to call one a prediction.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Cover this until after your first attempt

These scenarios explore different conditions; neither is a promise about the future. Let's identify the signals we would monitor and which decisions we would revisit if conditions changed.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Execution Governance, Operating Model, KPIs, and Board Narrative

SHARED CASE

A board presentation has twelve metrics but no clear request. The sponsor needs approval for a limited pilot.

Role A | Responding professional

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Useful expressions

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The decision today is whether to authorize the pilot. I'll lead with that request, the proposed scope, and the measures for reviewing it, then use the remaining metrics as supporting detail.

Second round

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Lesson conversations and speaking practice

The following sections match 05 and 06 on the industry webpage and in the learner workbook. Each lesson has three ten-turn conversations and two bounded speaking scenarios. These are original fictional teaching scripts, not transcripts of real people.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Which growth problem are we solving?

The lesson's executive requests a growth strategy without specifying revenue, profit, or market entry as the priority.

01 • Strategy lead: When you ask for a growth strategy, is the priority revenue, profit, or entry into another market?

02 • Executive sponsor: I haven't chosen among those. I was assuming the same strategy would deliver all three.

03 • Strategy lead: They may involve different choices. Could we clarify the ambition before building a strategic thesis?

04 • Executive sponsor: What would a precise diagnosis add beyond a list of attractive growth initiatives?

05 • Strategy lead: It identifies the problem we're trying to solve, rather than assuming every opportunity addresses it.

06 • Executive sponsor: Then our issue tree should separate those three possible objectives instead of merge them.

07 • Strategy lead: Exactly. We can ask what evidence would make each objective a priority and what constraints apply.

08 • Executive sponsor: Please bring those questions into the discussion without inventing a target or investment budget.

09 • Strategy lead: I will. The immediate output is a clarified decision question, not a fully approved growth direction.

10 • Executive sponsor: Good. Let's establish the objective before requesting initiatives that might answer the wrong question.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Retention or acquisition behind the revenue concern

Separate fictional strategy diagnosis: customer acquisition is unchanged, repeat purchases have fallen, and leadership asks for more advertising. Causes are unconfirmed.

01 • Commercial director: Revenue needs attention. Could you build a strategy around increasing advertising immediately?

02 • Strategy analyst: Before selecting a response, can we clarify the problem? Acquisition is unchanged, while repeat purchases have fallen.

03 • Commercial director: So our diagnosis should examine retention rather than assume new-customer volume caused the weakness.

04 • Strategy analyst: It should investigate repeat purchasing, yes, without claiming we already know why it declined.

05 • Commercial director: Could the issue tree separate purchase frequency, customer loss, and changes in order value?

06 • Strategy analyst: Yes. Those are questions to test, not confirmed causes supplied by the current figures.

07 • Commercial director: What would you ask me to clarify about the ambition for this work?

08 • Strategy analyst: Whether we are prioritizing restored repeat revenue, total revenue growth, or profitability, and over what horizon.

09 • Commercial director: I'll define that objective before treating additional advertising as the strategic thesis.

10 • Strategy analyst: Then we can assess interventions against the actual diagnosis rather than start with a favored solution.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A capacity symptom needs a bounded question

Separate fictional strategy exercise: one service team has a six-week backlog, while capacity elsewhere in the company has not been assessed.

01 • Chief operating officer: One team has a six-week backlog. Should our strategy be to acquire another service company?

02 • Strategy director: Could we first clarify whether the priority is reducing that backlog or expanding long-term capability?

03 • Chief operating officer: I was treating them as the same problem, but the immediate concern is waiting work.

04 • Strategy director: Then our diagnosis should examine demand, capacity, and work flow before selecting an acquisition response.

05 • Chief operating officer: Do we know whether another internal team has spare capacity that could help?

06 • Strategy director: No. Capacity elsewhere hasn't been assessed, so we shouldn't assume either spare resources or universal shortage.

07 • Chief operating officer: Let's frame the issue around the affected service and the six-week backlog first.

08 • Strategy director: Agreed. An issue tree can organize the questions without making the proposed acquisition the answer in advance.

09 • Chief operating officer: I'll clarify the desired service outcome and any constraints for that investigation.

10 • Strategy director: Then we'll assess strategic options after the problem and evidence are properly defined.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

An executive asks for a "growth strategy" but has not specified whether the priority is revenue, profit, or market entry.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: Which outcome are we trying to improve, over what period?
Revenue growth, profit improvement, and entry into a new market may require different choices. Let's define the decision first.

Scenario 2 | Efficiency has two meanings

In a fictional executive discussion, finance means lower total cost by efficiency, while operations means shorter customer waiting time. No preferred objective or numeric target is agreed.

Role A: You are the strategy facilitator. Clarify the two objectives and ask which decision the analysis should support.

Role B: You sponsor the work. Explain why the objectives may require different evidence and remain unprioritized.

Possible opening: Could we distinguish lower total cost from shorter waiting time before calling this one efficiency objective?

Success checks

- Name both meanings accurately.
- Keep the target and priority unagreed.
- Agree a bounded objective-setting question before choosing initiatives.

Add a complication: A participant wants a target announced immediately without a baseline.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Core improvement and market entry share the same people

The lesson's team can invest in its core service or enter a new segment; staff capacity is limited and shared.

01 • Strategy manager: Both options use the same limited staff. We can't compare them as if each had a separate team.

02 • Business sponsor: Could we call both priorities and ask people to deliver them alongside normal work?

03 • Strategy manager: That avoids the tradeoff rather than resolves it. The opportunity cost is what those people cannot do instead.

04 • Business sponsor: The core-service option strengthens existing work, whereas segment entry pursues a new customer group.

05 • Strategy manager: Yes. We should compare the same staffing period, expected outcomes, and uncertainty for both.

06 • Business sponsor: We haven't quantified those outcomes, so neither option has a proven higher return yet.

07 • Strategy manager: Correct. The activity system also matters: which supporting work each choice would require.

08 • Business sponsor: I'll ask both proposal owners to identify displaced work instead of hiding the resource conflict.

09 • Strategy manager: Then we can present a real strategic choice with common criteria and its weaker side visible.

10 • Business sponsor: Good. Our next discussion will prioritize, not simply add two labels to an overloaded team.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A focused pilot or a wider launch

Separate fictional strategy exercise: with the same six-person team for a quarter, option A serves one segment and includes research; B serves three segments but has no research capacity.

01 • Growth director: Option B reaches three segments, so it looks stronger than the one-segment pilot.

02 • Strategy analyst: Both use six people for the quarter, but only A includes capacity for customer research.

03 • Growth director: Then the tradeoff is broader initial coverage versus more deliberate learning in one segment.

04 • Strategy analyst: Exactly. More segments doesn't itself prove more profitable growth, especially with their needs still untested.

05 • Growth director: Could we keep B's reach and add A's research without changing the team?

06 • Strategy analyst: Not under these supplied options. We'd need to reassess scope rather than assume extra capacity.

07 • Growth director: I favor learning first, but want the lost early coverage stated as the opportunity cost.

08 • Strategy analyst: I'll make that explicit and retain the same quarterly staffing basis for the comparison.

09 • Growth director: Then the recommendation can explain a strategic choice instead of calling one option best at everything.

10 • Strategy analyst: Agreed. We can propose A for review while keeping its narrower reach visible.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Customization versus a repeatable service

Separate fictional strategy workshop: option A offers bespoke implementations with more configuration work; B standardizes the service but excludes some requested custom features. Revenue effects are unknown.

01 • Product director: The bespoke option answers more individual requests. Should we call it the obvious way to win?

02 • Operations strategist: It also requires more configuration work, whereas the standardized option excludes some custom features.

03 • Product director: So we should compare customer fit and delivery effort rather than count features alone.

04 • Operations strategist: Yes. Those choices imply different activity systems, not just different descriptions of the same offer.

05 • Product director: Do we know whether broader customization produces enough revenue to justify that work?

06 • Operations strategist: No. Revenue effects are unknown here, so neither margin advantage is established.

07 • Product director: I'll describe the opportunity cost of standardization as requests we deliberately don't support.

08 • Operations strategist: And describe the bespoke option's tradeoff as additional configuration work rather than free flexibility.

09 • Product director: Let's assess both over the same customer scope and planning horizon before recommending one.

10 • Operations strategist: Good. A useful strategic choice states what we give up as clearly as what we pursue.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Strategic Choices: Ambition, Where to Play, How to Win, and Tradeoffs

A team can invest in its core service or enter a new segment. The same staff would support both, and capacity is limited.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Second round: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for scenario 1: The two options compete for the same team. Expanding the core uses existing capabilities; entering the segment requires new ones. We should make the resource tradeoff explicit before selecting a direction.

Scenario 2 | Support hours or development capacity

A fictional team can allocate two specialists for the next quarter either to longer support hours or to a product improvement project. Existing hours and project scope would otherwise remain unchanged.

Role A: You are the strategy analyst. Compare the alternatives on the same staffing period.

Role B: You sponsor the decision. State a preferred benefit and acknowledge the work forgone.

Possible opening: The same two specialists can extend support or work on the improvement project, so choosing one displaces the other.

Success checks

- Keep the two-specialist quarterly constraint explicit.
- State the benefit and opportunity cost of each option.
- Offer a reviewable priority rather than promise both.

Add a complication: A stakeholder asks you to announce both outcomes without additional resources.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Industry spending exceeds the serviceable segment

The lesson's market estimate uses total industry spending, but the company can serve only one customer segment.

01 • Strategy analyst: The estimate uses total industry spending, while our current offer can serve only one customer segment.

02 • Executive sponsor: Can we present that total as the market we can realistically capture?

03 • Strategy analyst: No. Total addressable market and our serviceable market need to be distinguished before discussing obtainable share.

04 • Executive sponsor: So TAM, SAM, and SOM shouldn't all carry the same number by default.

05 • Strategy analyst: Correct. We haven't established the relevant segment size or a defensible obtainable share here.

06 • Executive sponsor: Could a large industry total still tell us where the profit pool sits?

07 • Strategy analyst: Not by itself. Spending volume doesn't identify where profits are earned within the industry.

08 • Executive sponsor: I'll keep the industry context but remove the claim that all of it is serviceable.

09 • Strategy analyst: I'll request segment evidence and clarify which assumptions would support an obtainable-market estimate.

10 • Executive sponsor: Good. The opportunity statement should match our actual reach rather than a broad headline number.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A market-share aspiration is not a sales forecast

Separate fictional sizing exercise: a serviceable market is estimated at \$20 million, and a team proposes a 5% share target without acquisition evidence.

01 • Business development lead: Five percent of the twenty-million-dollar estimate is one million. Can we call that next year's sales forecast?

02 • Strategy researcher: The arithmetic works, but the five-percent share is an aspiration without acquisition evidence.

03 • Business development lead: Then the one-million-dollar figure is conditional on an unsupported share assumption.

04 • Strategy researcher: Exactly. A serviceable market estimate doesn't establish an obtainable market or a timed revenue forecast.

05 • Business development lead: What would make the SOM discussion more grounded than selecting a convenient percentage?

06 • Strategy researcher: Evidence about reach, capacity, conversion, and relevant competition, with the assumptions stated explicitly.

07 • Business development lead: We haven't supplied those inputs, so I'll present the share as a proposed target only.

08 • Strategy researcher: Also preserve uncertainty in the twenty-million-dollar estimate rather than treat it as exact measured demand.

09 • Business development lead: I'll separate market estimate, share ambition, and sales forecast in the meeting.

10 • Strategy researcher: Good. That prevents correct multiplication from disguising an unsupported commercial conclusion.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

More revenue does not locate the profit pool

Separate fictional industry exercise: distribution has higher reported revenue than specialist servicing, but comparable cost data is unavailable.

01 • Strategy associate: Distribution reports more revenue than specialist servicing. Is that where the largest profit pool must be?

02 • Strategy director: Not necessarily. Revenue and profit differ, and comparable cost data isn't available here.

03 • Strategy associate: So industry scale doesn't by itself establish where value is retained after costs.

04 • Strategy director: Correct. We also need comparable business boundaries before interpreting the two reported figures.

05 • Strategy associate: Could we assume servicing has higher margins because it sounds more specialized?

06 • Strategy director: No. That would substitute a plausible story for evidence about actual economics.

07 • Strategy associate: I'll describe the observed revenue difference and identify profitability as an open question.

08 • Strategy director: Good. Our market-entry discussion should not treat an unmeasured profit pool as confirmed.

09 • Strategy associate: I'll seek comparable cost and scope information before recommending where to compete.

10 • Strategy director: Then the analysis can distinguish industry structure evidence from assumptions about attractive returns.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Industry Structure, Competitive Dynamics, and Profit Pools

A market estimate is based on total industry spending, but the company can serve only one customer segment.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: Total industry spending is broader than our addressable opportunity. I'll separate the overall market from the segment we can serve and explain the assumptions used to estimate our potential share.

Scenario 2 | Global spending with a regional offer

A fictional market slide uses a global spending estimate, but the company's current service is available in one region. That region's share of spending is unmeasured.

Role A: You review the sizing. Explain the gap between global context and current serviceability.

Role B: You prepared the slide. Identify the regional evidence needed without inventing a share.

Possible opening: The global figure provides context, but it doesn't establish the market our current regional offer can serve.

Success checks

- Distinguish global spending from current reach.
- Reject an unsupported equal-share assumption.
- Agree a regional evidence request and qualified sizing statement.

Add a complication: A sponsor suggests dividing the global estimate equally among regions despite no supporting evidence.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Growth with negative contribution

The lesson's new service has rising revenue but negative contribution after variable delivery costs; a slide calls growth proof of a sound model.

01 • Business unit director: Revenue is growing. Why can't we call that proof of a sound business model?

02 • Strategy finance lead: The service has negative contribution after variable delivery costs, so growth alone doesn't establish sound economics.

03 • Business unit director: Could you explain contribution in terms the operating team will recognize?

04 • Strategy finance lead: Here, it's revenue minus those variable delivery costs, before considering the other costs not included.

05 • Business unit director: So more sales can coexist with an unfavorable contribution, rather than automatically create margin expansion.

06 • Strategy finance lead: Exactly. We need to understand the value drivers and costs before claiming profitable scaling.

07 • Business unit director: Does negative contribution alone settle our long-term right to win in the market?

08 • Strategy finance lead: No. That broader capability question also needs evidence; neither conclusion follows from revenue growth alone.

09 • Business unit director: I'll separate demand growth from the unresolved economic and capability questions.

10 • Strategy finance lead: Good. The slide should explain what improved and what still undermines the model.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A contribution calculation before fixed costs

Separate fictional service example: each job earns \$80 and incurs \$50 variable delivery cost; fixed overhead and invested capital are not supplied.

01 • Service director: Each job earns eighty dollars and costs fifty in variable delivery. Is thirty dollars our final profit?

02 • Strategy analyst: It is contribution per job in this example, not final profit after all costs.

03 • Service director: Because fixed overhead hasn't been deducted from that thirty-dollar difference.

04 • Strategy analyst: Correct. And we haven't supplied invested capital, so this doesn't establish return on invested capital, or ROIC.

05 • Service director: Then a useful value driver might be delivery efficiency, but we still need evidence about feasible improvements.

06 • Strategy analyst: Exactly. A smaller variable cost would change contribution in the model, not prove an improvement has occurred.

07 • Service director: I'll explain the eighty-minus-fifty calculation and keep the missing overhead visible.

08 • Strategy analyst: Good. That lets colleagues understand unit economics without mistaking one layer for complete profitability.

09 • Service director: We'll discuss margin expansion only with the relevant cost basis and assumptions clear.

10 • Strategy analyst: Agreed. The simple calculation should illuminate the model, not conceal its incomplete inputs.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Owning data is not yet a right to win

Separate fictional strategy review: a company owns a historical service dataset but has not tested its usefulness for a proposed analytics product.

01 • Product strategist: We own the historical dataset. Doesn't that give us a right to win in analytics?

02 • Strategy director: It may be an asset, but we haven't tested its usefulness for the proposed customer problem.

03 • Product strategist: So a resource is something we possess, while a capability is what we can reliably do with it.

04 • Strategy director: Exactly. Advantage also depends on whether that capability creates relevant value compared with alternatives.

05 • Product strategist: Could we call the dataset a proven value driver before customers use the proposed product?

06 • Strategy director: Not on this evidence. Its relevance and practical usefulness remain hypotheses to assess.

07 • Product strategist: I'll describe the dataset as a potential input, not proof of a defensible business model.

08 • Strategy director: Good. Also identify any usage constraints before assuming every record is available for the new purpose.

09 • Product strategist: We'll test usefulness and clarify constraints before presenting a right-to-win claim.

10 • Strategy director: That distinguishes a promising resource from demonstrated capability and competitive advantage.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Business Models, Unit Economics, Capabilities, and Advantage

A new service has positive revenue growth but negative contribution after variable delivery costs. A slide calls growth proof of a sound business model.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: Growth shows demand, but it does not by itself demonstrate attractive unit economics. Let's explain the revenue and variable costs per unit before drawing conclusions about the model.

Scenario 2 | Automation savings exclude support work

A fictional service model shows ten minutes less manual processing per job, but any additional support work has not been measured. A slide claims total delivery cost fell.

Role A: You explain unit economics. Separate observed processing time from full delivery cost.

Role B: You own operations. Ask what support and cost evidence is needed to assess margin improvement.

Possible opening: Processing takes ten fewer minutes, but total delivery cost hasn't been established without the support work.

Success checks

- Preserve the ten-minute observation.
- Distinguish task time, delivery cost, and profit.
- Agree to measure missing work before claiming margin expansion.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call the time difference a verified profit increase.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Two investment requests need displaced-work choices

The lesson's two divisions request the same investment budget; neither explains what work would stop if funded.

01 • Portfolio director: Both divisions request the same investment budget. What would each stop or defer if it were funded?

02 • Division sponsor: Neither proposal identifies displaced work. We presented them as additions to the current portfolio.

03 • Portfolio director: Then capital allocation isn't fully described. The resource tradeoff needs to be explicit.

04 • Division sponsor: Could we approve the preferred proposal first and decide what to stop later?

05 • Portfolio director: We can take it for review, but shouldn't promise resources without examining the competing commitments.

06 • Division sponsor: I'll ask each division for a funded option and the work it would defer.

07 • Portfolio director: Good. Distinguish protecting the core business from exploring an adjacency, without assuming one always wins.

08 • Division sponsor: We'll also identify approvals required before either option becomes a commitment.

09 • Portfolio director: Then we can negotiate scope or sequencing with the consequences visible.

10 • Division sponsor: Agreed. The next review will contain choices, not two requests that both assume the full budget.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Funding a pilot by deferring a rollout

Separate fictional portfolio exercise: a team has a fixed \$100,000 budget. A \$20,000 adjacency pilot could be funded only by reducing a planned \$100,000 core rollout to \$80,000; approval is pending.

01 • Innovation sponsor: Could we fund the twenty-thousand-dollar adjacency pilot within the existing hundred-thousand-dollar budget?

02 • Portfolio manager: Only by reducing the planned core rollout to eighty thousand under this proposal.

03 • Innovation sponsor: Then my offer is a smaller pilot funded through a defined reduction, not extra money.

04 • Portfolio manager: Yes. What core rollout work would the twenty-thousand-dollar reduction actually defer?

05 • Innovation sponsor: That scope hasn't been identified yet, so I can't claim the core business is unaffected.

06 • Portfolio manager: Please obtain that detail before we ask for approval of the capital allocation.

07 • Innovation sponsor: If the reduced rollout is acceptable, can we take both linked scopes for review?

08 • Portfolio manager: Yes, as a conditional proposal. I can't confirm approval or resource release today.

09 • Innovation sponsor: I'll keep the two budgets together and show the deferred work once assessed.

10 • Portfolio manager: Good. The funding conversation will expose the tradeoff instead of presenting the pilot as free.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A divestiture idea cannot fund spending yet

Separate fictional portfolio review: a team proposes selling a noncore unit to fund investment, but no buyer, valuation, or sale timing is confirmed.

01 • Business sponsor: Could we commit the new investment now and pay for it from the planned divestiture?

02 • Capital allocation lead: The sale is only a proposal. Buyer, value, and timing are all unconfirmed.

03 • Business sponsor: Then what can we offer the investment team without promising unavailable proceeds?

04 • Capital allocation lead: We can assess a staged proposal with funding conditions explicit, rather than authorize the full spend.

05 • Business sponsor: Would the first stage also need its own identified funding and approval?

06 • Capital allocation lead: Yes. Calling a stage small doesn't create budget or remove the decision requirement.

07 • Business sponsor: I'll request a bounded scope and distinguish its funding from the hypothetical sale.

08 • Capital allocation lead: Good. Keep the noncore-unit review separate from any conclusion that divestiture is already agreed.

09 • Business sponsor: Then our recommendation can present the dependency and alternative sequencing for decision.

10 • Capital allocation lead: Exactly. Negotiate what can be assessed now without converting a possible transaction into cash on hand.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Portfolio Strategy, Capital Allocation, and Resource Reallocation

Two divisions request the same investment budget. Neither proposal explains what work would stop if it were funded.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Second round: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Model for scenario 1: Could each division identify the expected benefit, key assumption, and activity it would deprioritize? That would let us compare the proposals as allocation choices rather than separate wish lists.

Scenario 2 | Shared specialists block two funded projects

Two fictional portfolio projects each have budget approval, but both require the same specialist during the same month. Only one month's specialist capacity is available; project sequencing is undecided.

Role A: You manage the portfolio. Explain why funding approval doesn't resolve the staffing conflict.

Role B: You sponsor one project. Offer a sequencing proposal and state what would be delayed.

Possible opening: Both budgets are approved, but the shared specialist cannot cover both projects in the same month.

Success checks

- Separate budget from specialist capacity.
- Offer a concrete sequencing tradeoff.
- Keep the changed delivery commitments subject to review.

Add a complication: A sponsor asks you to confirm parallel delivery because the money is already allocated.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Possible synergies without an integration estimate

The lesson's acquisition proposal lists possible cost savings but has no integration plan or implementation estimate.

01 • Acquisition sponsor: The proposal lists cost savings. Can we present them as the acquisition's confirmed value creation?

02 • Strategy lead: No. They are possible synergies, and we lack an integration plan and implementation estimate.

03 • Acquisition sponsor: Then gross savings and net benefit are different claims in this discussion.

04 • Strategy lead: Exactly. Post-merger integration, or PMI, may require costs and work that aren't estimated here.

05 • Acquisition sponsor: Could we assume integration is straightforward because the businesses look similar?

06 • Strategy lead: Similarity isn't evidence that systems, roles, and operating processes will combine easily.

07 • Acquisition sponsor: I'll label the savings as proposed and identify the missing implementation work.

08 • Strategy lead: Good. The build-buy-partner comparison should include realistic execution assumptions for each route.

09 • Acquisition sponsor: We'll seek integration input before treating the acquisition as the proven best growth option.

10 • Strategy lead: Then leadership can distinguish strategic logic from benefits that still need validation and delivery.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A partnership discussion is not secured market access

Separate fictional market-entry exercise: a potential distributor has expressed interest, but no agreement, coverage commitment, or commercial terms are established.

01 • Market entry director: The distributor is interested. Can the strategy update say we've secured access to the market?

02 • Partnerships lead: Not yet. Interest isn't an agreement, and coverage commitments and commercial terms remain open.

03 • Market entry director: Then the partner route is a potential option, not a completed market-entry capability.

04 • Partnerships lead: Correct. We should also assess what the distributor can actually deliver rather than infer reach from enthusiasm.

05 • Market entry director: Could we include projected sales as guaranteed because a channel conversation is underway?

06 • Partnerships lead: No. That would add certainty unsupported by either the relationship or demand evidence.

07 • Market entry director: I'll report the discussion milestone and the unresolved commercial questions separately.

08 • Partnerships lead: Good. We can compare build, buy, and partner routes without calling the partner route secured.

09 • Market entry director: Please bring the next evidence needed for a credible coverage assessment.

10 • Partnerships lead: I will, with any scenario assumptions clearly separated from confirmed commitments.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Overlapping teams do not prove removable costs

Separate fictional acquisition exercise: both firms have customer-support teams, but workload, service requirements, and integration costs have not been assessed.

01 • Deal analyst: Both firms have support teams. Can we count one team's cost as an automatic synergy?

02 • Integration manager: No. Overlapping job labels don't show that the combined workload can be handled by one team.

03 • Deal analyst: So the observation is duplication of functions, not confirmed removable capacity.

04 • Integration manager: Exactly. We need workload, service requirements, and implementation costs before estimating a defensible net benefit.

05 • Deal analyst: Would using a standard percentage reduction make the estimate more credible?

06 • Integration manager: Only if it has relevant support. A convenient percentage doesn't replace an integration assessment.

07 • Deal analyst: I'll describe a potential support-efficiency opportunity and keep the savings amount unestablished.

08 • Integration manager: Good. PMI planning also needs to consider service continuity rather than treat every overlap as unnecessary.

09 • Deal analyst: We'll request the operational evidence before including a firm saving in the acquisition case.

10 • Integration manager: Then the synergy discussion can move from a plausible idea to an assessed proposal.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Growth Strategy, Market Entry, Partnerships, and M&A Logic

An acquisition proposal lists possible cost savings. No integration plan or implementation estimate has been prepared.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: These are potential synergies, not confirmed savings. I'll distinguish the opportunity from the work and cost required to achieve it so the proposal presents a balanced strategic case.

Scenario 2 | A build estimate excludes customer support

A fictional build-buy-partner comparison prices the build option's software development but omits ongoing customer support. The other options include support estimates. No preferred route is approved.

Role A: You review the strategy case. Identify the scope mismatch and limit the cost conclusion.

Role B: You own the build proposal. Ask for support requirements and retain the estimate as partial.

Possible opening: The build figure excludes customer support, so it isn't yet comparable with the other two estimates.

Success checks

- Identify the omitted support scope.
- Keep the build total and route preference unconfirmed.
- Agree a consistent-scope assessment before ranking options.

Add a complication: A sponsor wants to call building the cheapest route before the missing work is costed.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Comparing scenarios without naming a prediction

Separate fictional quarterly planning exercise: option A reserves capacity for 100 jobs at a total quarterly cost of \$10,000; B reserves 60 jobs for \$6,000. Both cover the same service and quarter. Base-case demand is 90 jobs; downside demand is 50. Demand figures are assumptions, and revenue is unestimated.

01 • Planning sponsor: The base case assumes ninety jobs this quarter; the downside assumes fifty. Which is our prediction?

02 • Strategy facilitator: Neither is established as a prediction. Let's compare both capacity options under those assumptions.

03 • Planning sponsor: A provides one hundred slots for ten thousand dollars, while B provides sixty for six thousand.

04 • Strategy facilitator: In the base case, A covers ninety jobs; B leaves thirty beyond its reserved capacity.

05 • Planning sponsor: In the downside case, both cover fifty, but A has fifty unused slots and B ten.

06 • Strategy facilitator: Correct. A costs four thousand more for the same quarter but accommodates higher demand.

07 • Planning sponsor: So B limits committed cost, whereas A provides more capacity if the base case occurs.

08 • Strategy facilitator: Yes. Revenue is unestimated, so this comparison doesn't establish which option would be more profitable.

09 • Planning sponsor: Let's take that cost-capacity tradeoff for review instead of calling either scenario certain.

10 • Strategy facilitator: Agreed. We'll retain both demand assumptions and the residual uncertainty in the recommendation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A short lease preserves flexibility at a higher cost

Separate fictional strategy exercise: a one-year facility option costs more annually but preserves an earlier exit; a three-year option costs less annually but commits longer. Other terms are unassessed.

01 • Operations director: The three-year option is cheaper annually. Should we choose it under both demand scenarios?

02 • Strategy analyst: It also commits us longer, whereas the one-year option costs more but preserves an earlier exit.

03 • Operations director: Then the strategic option we're comparing includes flexibility, not simply annual price.

04 • Strategy analyst: Exactly. Under uncertain demand, the ability to reconsider earlier may matter, but its value isn't quantified here.

05 • Operations director: Could we say the short option is always safer without checking the other terms?

06 • Strategy analyst: No. Other terms remain unassessed, and different scenarios may make the tradeoff look different.

07 • Operations director: I'll compare annual cost and commitment length consistently, with demand assumptions stated.

08 • Strategy analyst: Good. Don't compare one year's total with three years' total as though the periods match.

09 • Operations director: We'll review the remaining terms before recommending how much flexibility to preserve.

10 • Strategy analyst: Then the decision can acknowledge both the price advantage and the longer commitment it buys.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A review trigger is not an automatic expansion order

Separate fictional plan: two consecutive months above a demand threshold trigger strategy review, not automatic expansion. Only one month qualifies. For the coming month, preparation-only would cost \$2,000 for a capacity assessment and create no external contract; immediate expansion would cost \$12,000 monthly under a six-month capacity contract. Neither option is approved.

01 • Commercial sponsor: Demand crossed the threshold once. Can we expand next month instead of only preparing?

02 • Strategy manager: The trigger requires two consecutive months and initiates review, not automatic expansion. Neither option is approved.

03 • Commercial sponsor: Compare the coming month's commitments so I can see what each option actually involves.

04 • Strategy manager: Preparation costs two thousand dollars for an assessment; expansion costs twelve thousand for capacity next month.

05 • Commercial sponsor: That's ten thousand more next month. Does expansion also commit us beyond that period?

06 • Strategy manager: Yes, twelve thousand monthly for six months. Preparation creates no external contract, but adds no capacity.

07 • Commercial sponsor: So preparation preserves flexibility, whereas expansion supplies capacity sooner with a longer financial commitment.

08 • Strategy manager: Exactly. One qualifying month doesn't establish sustained demand or justify treating either option as authorized.

09 • Commercial sponsor: I'll take preparation as my preferred proposal for review, with the capacity limitation explicit.

10 • Strategy manager: I'll record that preference, not approval. The second demand month and any spending decision remain pending.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Uncertainty, Scenarios, Strategic Options, and Risk Posture

A planning workshop has a base case and a downside case. The team wants to call one a prediction.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Second round: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for scenario 1: These scenarios explore different conditions; neither is a promise about the future. Let's identify the signals we would monitor and which decisions we would revisit if conditions changed.

Scenario 2 | A reversible pilot versus a permanent rollout

A fictional strategy team compares a three-month pilot that can be stopped at review with a permanent rollout requiring a longer commitment. Costs and customer outcomes are not yet estimated.

Role A: You are the strategy analyst. Compare commitment and learning while preserving missing economic information.

Role B: You sponsor the choice. Explain which flexibility matters and ask what would trigger further investment.

Possible opening: The pilot provides an earlier review point, whereas the rollout commits us longer; their costs remain unestimated.

Success checks

- State the three-month review point and longer rollout commitment.
- Avoid claiming reversibility removes all risk or cost.
- Agree evidence needed for the next investment decision.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call the pilot risk-free because it can be stopped.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Twelve metrics and one missing request

Separate fictional extension of the lesson: a twelve-metric board presentation seeks approval for a four-week, twenty-account pilot. Operations estimates ten support hours weekly, but only six are available. Additional staffing and pilot approval are unconfirmed; the board holds approval authority.

01 • Strategy director: Our twelve metrics don't state the request. What decision are we asking the board to make?

02 • Executive sponsor: Approval for a four-week pilot with twenty accounts, not a permanent rollout or immediate expansion.

03 • Strategy director: Before presenting that request, operations, what constraint does the board need to hear?

04 • Operations lead: The pilot needs ten support hours weekly, but we have six. Four hours remain uncovered.

05 • Strategy director: So the proposed scope exceeds available support. Can we assume colleagues will absorb those four hours?

06 • Operations lead: No. Additional staffing is unconfirmed. We should assess extra coverage or a smaller pilot scope.

07 • Strategy director: That makes support capacity an unresolved condition. Sponsor, will you own presenting the conditional request?

08 • Executive sponsor: Yes. I'll present the scope and coverage gap, with board approval explicitly pending.

09 • Strategy director: Operations, please own the coverage-options assessment before that discussion. Can you confirm the handoff?

10 • Operations lead: I accept that assessment. I'll return feasible options, not promise additional staffing; pilot approval remains pending.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A KPI owner is not automatically the decision owner

Separate fictional pilot: conversion improved, and analytics owns reporting that KPI. The sponsor alone decides extension. A proposed fifty-client extension requires twenty support hours weekly; operations has twelve available. Additional coverage is unconfirmed, and extension is unapproved.

01 • Program manager: Conversion improved. Can analytics announce the proposed fifty-client extension, or is another decision needed?

02 • Analytics lead: I own the KPI report, not extension approval. The sponsor holds that decision right.

03 • Program manager: Operations, what would supporting fifty clients require, and what capacity do you actually have?

04 • Operations lead: We need twenty support hours weekly and have twelve available. Eight hours remain uncovered.

05 • Program manager: Then improved conversion doesn't resolve delivery capacity. Would a smaller scope or extra coverage need assessment?

06 • Operations lead: Yes. Neither solution is confirmed, so we cannot promise support for fifty clients yet.

07 • Program manager: Analytics, please provide the measured result without an approval claim. Can you own that part?

08 • Analytics lead: Yes. I'll provide the KPI evidence and distinguish it from the sponsor's pending extension decision.

09 • Program manager: Operations, will you own assessing coverage or reduced scope? We'll present that gap alongside the KPI.

10 • Operations lead: I accept the assessment and will return the options. The fifty-client extension remains unapproved pending the sponsor's review.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A steering meeting ends with an unresolved owner

Separate fictional execution review: commercial and operations teams each assume the other owns customer onboarding in a proposed service; no ownership decision has been made.

01 • Steering chair: Commercial and operations each expect the other to own onboarding. We need to resolve that operating-model question.

02 • Program director: Could we list both teams as owners and move to the next agenda item?

03 • Steering chair: Shared participation doesn't explain who is accountable for the decision and the actual handoff.

04 • Program director: Then we should hear what each team can own before proposing an allocation.

05 • Steering chair: Exactly. Invite both perspectives, including any capacity constraints we haven't assessed.

06 • Program director: Who can confirm the final ownership arrangement after that discussion?

07 • Steering chair: That decision right hasn't been established in this exercise. We need the sponsor to clarify it.

08 • Program director: I'll record that as a specific action rather than infer agreement because nobody objected.

09 • Steering chair: Good. Close with onboarding ownership unresolved and the sponsor clarification assigned to you.

10 • Program director: I accept that action and won't describe the operating model as approved until the decision is confirmed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Execution Governance, Operating Model, KPIs, and Board Narrative

A board presentation has twelve metrics but no clear request. The sponsor needs approval for a limited pilot.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Second round: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Model for scenario 1: The decision today is whether to authorize the pilot. I'll lead with that request, the proposed scope, and the measures for reviewing it, then use the remaining metrics as supporting detail.

Scenario 2 | A board discussion praised the pilot but did not approve expansion

A fictional board discussion praised pilot learning but deferred the expansion decision until costs are reviewed. The draft internal update says expansion approved. Finance has not supplied the cost review.

Role A: You facilitate the follow-up. Restate the actual decision and invite finance's missing input.

Role B: You sponsor the pilot. Confirm the deferred decision and identify who will bring the cost review.

Possible opening: The board welcomed the learning but deferred expansion pending the cost review; approval has not been given.

Success checks

- Separate positive discussion from approval.
- Identify the pending finance input.
- Close with accurate decision status and a named follow-up responsibility.

Add a complication: A team lead wants to begin expansion because the feedback sounded positive.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Rehearse with an AI colleague

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Corporate Strategy English

Professional audience: corporate strategy, CEO office, transformation, corporate development, strategic finance, product strategy, and internal consulting teams

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Dialogue 01: CEO Request: 'We Need a Strategy'

Original fictional setting: The CEO asks the strategy team for a strategy, but the request sounds like a list of initiatives.

Professional roles: CEO / Strategy lead / Strategy manager

Published dialogue (reference script, not my own performance):

CEO: We need a strategy for next year. Give me the top twenty initiatives.

Strategy lead: We can build the initiative list, but first we need the strategic choice behind it.

Strategy manager: If the output is only a project list, we may miss the real decision. Are we trying to defend the core, enter a new segment, improve margins, or shift resources toward higher-growth businesses?

CEO: All of the above.

Strategy manager: Then the first decision is prioritization. We should define the few choices that matter most, the tradeoffs they imply, and the resources that must move.

CEO: Start by comparing the core choices and the resource constraints.

Strategy manager: I will prepare a short decision paper before translating the chosen direction into initiatives.

Vocabulary in this exchange: Strategic choice: Decision about where to focus, how to win, what to build, and what not to do.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Interactive workplace role-play

1. Use the supplied case or dialogue as the starting situation. Give a two-sentence briefing and offer two relevant professional roles for me to choose from. For a supplied dialogue, use its actual roles. Ask which role I want, then stop and wait. Do not write my replies.
2. After I choose, identify who you will play and the immediate communication goal. Play the other professional; where a meeting requires a third person, label each of your speakers clearly. Start with one natural workplace turn and wait for my reply. Keep most turns to one to three sentences and ask no more than one question at a time.
3. Let the exchange develop across six to ten learner turns, or end earlier if I type "feedback". Respond to what I actually say. Include a plausible clarification, disagreement or tradeoff without silently changing the starting facts. Mark any added constraint as a fictional second-round variation. Do not resolve approvals, evidence or commitments that remain uncertain.
4. Stay in role during the exchange. If my meaning is unclear, ask for clarification naturally. Give a hint only if I ask or cannot proceed. Do not deliver a model conversation in advance.
5. At the debrief, quote two of my phrases: one successful choice and one worth improving. Check factual accuracy, language, register and whether the next step was clear. Give up to three focused suggestions. Ask me to retry the weakest turn; wait. Only then offer an alternative wording and a harder replay.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Create more scenario dialogues

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

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CEO: All of the above.

Strategy manager: Then the first decision is prioritization. We should define the few choices that matter most, the tradeoffs they imply, and the resources that must move.

CEO: Start by comparing the core choices and the resource constraints.

Strategy manager: I will prepare a short decision paper before translating the chosen direction into initiatives.

Vocabulary in this exchange: Strategic choice: Decision about where to focus, how to win, what to build, and what not to do.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Extend the conversation library

1. Propose six distinct, common scenarios in this field beyond the supplied case or script. For each, name the setting, two or more professional roles, the communication problem and one useful terminology focus. Include routine coordination, clarification, a complication, disagreement, handoff and follow-up where relevant. Choose scenarios that fit this profession, rather than forcing unsuitable situations into it.
2. Ask me to choose one scenario, or request all six in sequence. Stop and wait. Do not write all the scripts before I choose.
3. For the selected scenario, write an original fictional dialogue of 12-18 substantial speaking turns between two or three professionals. Name each role, establish an actual work problem, and let the exchange progress through questions, clarification, competing constraints and a credible next step or explicitly unresolved issue. Use the occupation's natural nomenclature and register. Avoid an interview between a teacher and a learner, generic small talk, and inserting a glossary definition into every reply. Explain specialist terms outside the dialogue instead.
4. After the script, explain five useful expressions in context, identify two grammar or register choices and ask three questions about the speakers' reasoning. Withhold the answers until I attempt them. Add one role-switch challenge.
5. Before presenting a script, check names, numbers, chronology, roles and terminology for consistency. Label invented facts and acknowledge uncertain specialist usage. If I requested all six, deliver one complete script at a time and wait for "next". Make each scenario materially different.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level